

The grit, grind, and the gold

Paralympic gold medallist Navdeep Singh has come through financial struggles and societal doubts to **claim his place** among the best and brightest in javelin throw.

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New Delhi's Jawaharlal Nehru (JLN) Stadium is roughly three kilometres from Jangpura, a neighbourhood in South Delhi. A 17-year-old Navdeep Singh, taking his formative steps in javelin throw at the JLN, made the round trip on foot.

"Jo cheez bina paison ke ho sakti thi, vo humne bina paison ke ki hai (Whatever could be done to save money, I did). I used to stay in a paying guest accommodation near Kotla. I then moved to Jangpura and trained at the JLN Stadium. I never travelled by the [Delhi] Metro. It took me around 30 minutes to walk. It saved money, which I could then spend on my diet," Navdeep tells *Sportstar* on the sidelines of the Aces Awards in Mumbai.

Navdeep's interest in javelin developed later than it does for most athletes. Like nearly every child in Haryana, wrestling was his first love. Despite being aware of his condition — Dwarfism, caused by a genetic mutation affecting bone growth — his father, himself a wrestler, encouraged him to pursue the sport.

"My father was a sportsperson too. A big positive was that I received a lot of support from him. I took up wrestling for about three to four years. I even won a bronze medal at a State championship. Sports have been part of my life since childhood, and they are mostly individual sports. I also took part in sprints for a while," Navdeep says. He only discovered javelin throw after stumbling upon a Neeraj Chopra video on YouTube. Neeraj's gold medal at the 2016 Under-20 World Championships piqued his interest, prompting him to move to New Delhi.

"I was 17 when I left Panipat. I initially stayed in Sonapat with my aunt and commuted daily from her house. Eventually, my father moved me to Delhi, so it was a gradual process. I did not have to convince them to let me go," Navdeep says.

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One piece of advice you would give to 15-year-old Navdeep Singh

Be a little less mischievous

Your favourite cheat meal

Mutton Biryani

What do you do when you are not training

When I am not training, I am usually watching a film